Lesson 16: Grammar: Modals

English Stage 2 (B2) · Unit 2: Sentences and Paragraph Types · American History

Adapted from High-Intermediate Academic Grammar for ESL Students by Rebecca Al Haider, Reedley College (CC BY 4.0): 5.4: Grammar Presentation-Modals.

In this lesson

You will study the eight main modal auxiliaries and the expressions have to and used to. You will use them to show how certain you are, to make polite requests, to give advice, to talk about the past, and to express regret and criticism. In academic writing, modals show how sure you are of a claim (must, may, might) and how strong a recommendation is (should, must).

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Form statements, negatives and questions with a modal and a base verb.
- Show your level of certainty with must, may, might and could.
- Make polite requests and give advice with the right modal.
- Talk about past habits, abilities and necessities with used to, would, could and had to.
- Express regret and criticism with should have, could have and might have + past participle, and correct common modal errors.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
modal auxiliary (modal)	a helping verb used only with a main verb; it adds mood: ability, possibility, advice, necessity	James may call.
base verb (base form)	the simple form of a verb, with no to, -s, -ed or -ing	Should I **drive**?
possibility	something that is perhaps true or may happen	She might be sick.
inference	a strong guess based on what you see or know	He must be sick.
advisability (advice)	what is a good idea to do	You should drink hot water with honey.
obligation, necessity	something you must do; a rule or a requirement	I have to be at work at 9AM.
past participle	the third form of a verb (brought, eaten, called)	I should have brought a jacket.
regret	a feeling that you wish you had acted differently	I should not have eaten all the chocolate.

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
criticism	saying that someone did something wrong	You could have kept my secret!

Rules and explanations

Form

	Form	Example
Affirmative	subject + modal + base verb	James may call.
Negative	subject + modal + not + base verb	James may not call.
Yes/no question	modal + subject + base verb?	Should I drive?

A modal never changes its form: no -s (he must, not he musts), no -ed, and no to after it. (Have to and used to are not among the eight modals, so they keep their to.)

The eight main modals and their uses

Modal	Uses
can	ability; possibility; polite request
could	past ability; present possibility or suggestion; past or future permission; polite request
may	uncertain future action; permission; polite request
might	uncertain action
should	obligation; expectation; advisability
will	intended future action; asking a favor (Will you buy me some chocolate?) or for information
would	preference (I would like the steak, please); polite request; explaining an action; habitual past action
must	obligation; inference

1. Possibility and inference: how certain are you?

Your teacher is absent. You might say:

- She is sick. (100% certain: no modal)
- She must be sick. (about 95% certain)
- She may be sick. / She might be sick. / She could be sick. (less than 50% certain)

2. Polite requests

- Could, would and may are equally polite. Can is less formal but still polite: use it with people you know well.
- May asks permission, so its subject is I: May I have a cup of water? The other modals can have any subject: Could you give me a cup of water?

- Add please: Could I please have a cup of water? Also: Would you mind giving me a cup of water? (would you mind + verb-ing)

3. Advice, expectation, obligation and necessity

- **should** = advice (You should drink hot water with honey.), expectation (You should be finished with your reading by now.) or obligation (I should be at work at 9AM.).
- **must / have to** = strong necessity: I must be at work at 9AM. I have to be at work at 9AM.

4. Past situations that are no longer true

- used to + base verb (past habit): I used to travel to many countries.
- would + base verb (past habit): I would visit new and exciting places.
- could + base verb (past ability): I could handle the long flights with no problems.
- had to + base verb (past necessity): I had to save my money to buy my plane tickets.

5. Regret and criticism (past modals)

- Regret: subject + should / should not + have + past participle. I should have brought a jacket. I should not have eaten all the chocolate.
- Criticism: subject + might / could + have + past participle. You might have called me to say you were late. You could have kept my secret!
- Contractions: should've, shouldn't have, might've, could've.
- Present or past? should + base verb gives advice for now or the future. should have + past participle talks about the past, and the action did not happen.

Common errors

Error	Incorrect	Correct
infinitive after a modal	I can to move this heavy table.	I can move this heavy table.
gerund (-ing) after a modal	I could moving to the United States.	I could move to the United States.
two modals in a row	I should must renew my passport.	I must renew my passport. / I should renew my passport.
no modal	I renew my passport.	I must renew my passport.

> **Note for Arabic speakers** - In Arabic, the words for "must" and "can" are followed by a small word that works like "to" (yajib an, yastatee' an + verb), so learners often add to in English: "I must to study", "He can to swim". After the eight modals, use the base verb with no to.

Practice

Exercise 3: Inference practice. For each situation, write one sentence with must (strong inference) and one with may, might or could (less likely). Example: Your teacher's eyes are red. She must have allergies. / She might be high on drugs.

1. A restaurant is busy.
2. Your classmate is using crutches.
3. You see a dog at your friend's house.
4. Your classmate is sad after receiving her exam results.
5. Your classmate is coughing.
6. Your friend is wearing a sun hat and swim suit.
7. Your stomach is making noises.
8. You hear an ambulance.
9. You received a high grade on your homework.
10. You see your family member at the train station.

Exercise 4: Polite requests. Write how you would politely request what is needed.

1. You are emailing your instructor. You want to make an appointment to review the exam results.
2. You want to schedule time off from work so that you can visit your family in another city. You will ask your supervisor.
3. You are at the doctor's office waiting room. You have been waiting for a while and need to leave soon. The receptionist is available to ask about the wait time.
4. You want to use your brother's car since yours broke down.
5. You are with your classmate and want to use her phone to call your mom to pick you up.

Exercise 5: Should or must. Both answers are possible, but the meaning is different. Choose the most appropriate word for the intended meaning: a) should b) must.

1. According to my counselor, I _____ take 12 more units to graduate.
2. According to my counselor, I _____ meet with a tutor to improve my writing.
3. We _____ eat healthy.
4. Plants _____ have sun in order to live.
5. You _____ submit your homework in order to receive credit.

Exercise 6: Listening practice. Listen to Rachel talk about her childhood: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=AyBLyhLa5Ys. Listen before you read: the text is at the end of the Lesson 15 transcript ("Exercise-Listening Practice"). Mark each sentence a) True or b) False.

1. Rachel lives on a farm now.
2. She hung out with her friends on the weekends.
3. She had the ability to lift heavy items.
4. She didn't need to work on the farm if the weather was bad.

Exercise 7: Expressing regret and criticism. Rewrite with the modal in parentheses. Your sentence may be affirmative or negative. Example: I told Jennifer my secret. She talks a lot. (Should) I shouldn't have told Jennifer my secret.

1. I have spinach in my teeth. You didn't tell me! (Might)

2. The electricity bill is late. You sent the payment through the mail. (Could)
3. I made a lot of food for dinner. Now, I have a lot of leftovers. (Should)
4. I didn't bring an umbrella to class. The forecast predicted heavy rain. (Should)
5. Maria waited to sign up for Political Science. Now the only instructor available has bad reviews. (Might)
6. Huy's car broke down. He was absent for class and missed an important exam. His teacher won't let him make it up. (Could)

Exercise 11: Common modal errors. Find and correct the errors. (Items 1-10. More items: lesson material, Exercise 11. Your tutor can check them.)

1. She should to make dinner for her family every night.
2. He must drives his mother to the store tonight
3. It might raining in New York now.
4. I could played baseball every day when I was a boy.
5. I would ate dinner with my mother and father every day.
6. The girl has play with her friends after school tomorrow.
7. He musts goes to the doctor for the cut on his head.
8. Children should not be play with matches.
9. My big brother could ate a lot of food when he were a boy.
10. He might not sees the spider on his shirt.

Speak with your tutor

- "Give me ten situations like 'Your classmate is coughing'. For each one, I will make a strong inference with must and a weaker guess with may, might or could. Tell me if my level of certainty fits."
- "Ask me about my childhood. I will answer with used to, would, could and had to. Correct every verb after a modal."
- "I will describe three mistakes I made recently. Tell me what I should have done. Then describe three of your mistakes, and I will criticize them with could have and might have."
- "Check my answers to Exercise 9, Exercise 10 (the listening about Rachel's weekend) and Exercise 11, items 11 to 18, in the lesson material."

Read aloud

- Could you pass the handout to me?
- Would you mind giving me a cup of water?
- I used to travel to many countries. (used to = /ˈjuːstə/)
- I should have brought a jacket. (should have = /ˈʃʊdəv/)
- You could have kept my secret! (could have = /ˈkʊdəv/)

- You might have called me to say you were late. (might have = /ˈmaɪtəv/)

Writing task

Write a paragraph of 8-10 sentences about your childhood, like Rachel's paragraph in Exercise 6.

- Begin with a topic sentence, for example: "When I was a child, I lived in a small town."
- Use used to, would, could and had to at least once each.
- End with one regret (I should have / I should not have + past participle) and one piece of advice for children today (Children should ...).

Checklist:

- Is there a base verb after every modal (could lift, not could lifted)?
- Is there no to after can, could, would, should or must, while used to and had to keep their to?
- Is there only one modal in each verb (no "should must")?
- Is there a past participle after should have (should have studied, not should have study)?
- Are your other past verbs in the simple past?

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Watch online

- Modals of Possibility- May, Might, and Could: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=xE-04vBz3fg
- Modal Verbs used for asking Permission and Making Requests: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=tS3n8jf3bHI
- Past Modals: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=4nnPVne2C5w
- Using Perfect Modals to Express Regrets: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=hCaU3qHbGQU
- Rachel's weekend regrets (the listening for Exercise 10 in the lesson material): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Xx2wPR8SSlA

Answer key

Exercise 3. (example answer)

1. The food must be good. / There might be a special event today.
2. He must have a broken leg. / He might have a sore foot from running.
3. My friend must have a new dog. / He might be taking care of a neighbor's dog.
4. She must be disappointed with her grade. / She might be worried about something else.
5. He must have a cold. / He could be allergic to something in the room.
6. She must be going to the beach. / She might be going to a pool party.
7. I must be hungry. / I might be sick.
8. Someone must be hurt. / There may be a car accident nearby.
9. I must be good at this topic. / The teacher might be an easy grader.
10. He must be traveling somewhere. / He could be meeting a friend.

Exercise 4. (example answer)

1. Could I please make an appointment with you to review my exam results?
2. May I please take next Friday off? I would like to visit my family.
3. Could you please tell me how long the wait will be? I need to leave soon.
4. Can I use your car, please? Mine broke down. (can: he is your brother)
5. Could I please use your phone to call my mom?

Exercise 5. (book) 1. b must (a requirement) 2. a should (advice) 3. b must 4. b must 5. b must. In item 3, a (should) is also possible: should gives advice, while must makes healthy eating a strong necessity.

Exercise 6. (book) 1. b ("I used to live on a farm.") 2. a 3. a 4. b ("even when the weather was cold and wet").

Exercise 7. (Other endings are possible in 2, 5 and 6.)

1. You might have told me!
2. You could have paid the bill online.
3. I shouldn't have made so much food. (or: I should not have made so much food.)
4. I should have brought an umbrella to class.
5. Maria might have signed up for Political Science earlier.
6. His teacher could have let him make up the exam. (or: Huy could have called his teacher.)

Exercise 11. (The book's key says the same sentences again for every item except 3; this is a mistake because those sentences still contain the errors. The corrections for items 1-2 and 4-10 are not from the book.)

1. She should make dinner for her family every night.

2. He must drive his mother to the store tonight.
3. It might be raining in New York now. (book)
4. I could play baseball every day when I was a boy.
5. I would eat dinner with my mother and father every day.
6. The girl has to play with her friends after school tomorrow. (Also possible: will play / can play.)
7. He must go to the doctor for the cut on his head.
8. Children should not play with matches. (Also possible: should not be playing.)
9. My big brother could eat a lot of food when he was a boy.
10. He might not see the spider on his shirt.

My notes